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Disclosure: *Former-employer disclosure: NiCE is a former employer of the author. All NiCE research here is public-source only; no LinkedIn queries or visits were made for NiCE or Cognyte. The parent report is published at <https://productbeacon.agency/research/state-of-wem-2026/>.*

Workforce Engagement Management (WEM) covers the software that schedules, measures, coaches and assists contact-centre staff, and increasingly the AI agents working beside them.

This week's main developments

- Zendesk's chief executive said "seats are dead" and plans to drop seat pricing across the business within six months, The Next Web reports. Microsoft kept seats for everyday AI and put agent work on a meter.
- Sky News reports Brookfield is in exclusive talks to buy Actimize, NiCE's financial-crime software unit, for about \$2 billion. The deal is unconfirmed.
- Salesforce's own contact-centre service reaches the UK and EU in October, TechTarget reports. Workforce management features were previewed but have not shipped.
- Liberty Global signed a three-year deal to roll out Sierra's AI agents across about 80 million connections in Europe.
- Five California workplace and chatbot AI bills remain unsigned. Each becomes law unless vetoed by 30 September.

Zendesk says seats are dead; Microsoft keeps them for everyday AI

- Tom Eggemeier, Zendesk's chief executive, said at the HumanX conference in Amsterdam on 23 September: "Unequivocally: seats are dead."
- The Next Web reports Zendesk plans to drop seats across its business, with announcements due in three to six months. Charging per interaction would be a first step.
- Zendesk's price page still calls its pricing "primarily seat-based." Its prices per automated resolution, \$1.50 committed and \$2.00 pay-as-you-go, are unchanged.
- Only one outlet reported the remarks. Zendesk has published no release or transcript.

Microsoft splits Copilot pricing in two

- On 25 September Microsoft kept everyday AI inside the per-user monthly licence. Long-running agent work is now billed by usage through Copilot Credits.
- Credits can only be bought on top of the licence. Microsoft says putting everyday AI on a meter is "the wrong deal," because companies may ration access.
- This is Microsoft's general Copilot product. Its contact-centre price list did not change.
- Intercom's own pricing guide says that for teams using its Fin agent heavily, "the outcome charges often exceed the seat costs."
- **Our view:** no tracked vendor returned to per-seat pricing. Seats are staying for tools that help people, and meters are spreading for AI that does the work. Zendesk says it will go further and

drop the seat.

- **Watch:** Zendesk's promised announcements. It also sells workforce management and quality add-ons, so dropping seats "across its business" would reach those too.

NiCE's financial-crime unit is reported to be in sale talks

- Sky News reported on 23 September that Brookfield is in exclusive talks to buy Actimize from NiCE for about \$2 billion. Its sources cautioned the deal could still fall apart.
- Brookfield declined to comment. No NiCE comment appears in the reports, and NiCE's press page carries no statement.
- Calcalist reports Actimize had \$453.5 million of revenue in 2024, about 16.6% of NiCE's total, and nearly 29% of its operating profit.
- Calcalist reported in May that offers were around \$2.5 billion. The price now reported is lower.
- NiCE shares rose 9.1% on 21 September, two days before the report, when Five9 rose 14%. On the day of the report they closed 0.4% lower.
- **Our view:** if the sale goes ahead, NiCE becomes mainly a customer experience (CX) software company, alongside its public-safety unit. Its CX business would then carry the margin largely on its own.

Salesforce plans to take its contact-centre service abroad, with workforce management to follow

- TechTarget reports Salesforce's contact-centre service reaches the UK and EU in October, Australia and New Zealand in November, and Latin America early next year.
- **Correction to last week:** October is the UK and EU launch. US and Canadian customers have had the service since earlier this year.
- Workforce management features were previewed at Dreamforce, TechTarget reports. No ship date, price or feature list was given.
- Salesforce's price page lists a workforce management add-on at \$50 per user per month. The page is undated, so the listing may not be new.
- Opus Research reports Salesforce counts 1,200 new customers for the service since March. The count mixes customer types and carries no revenue figure.
- Kevin Lee, NiCE's chief technology officer, told TechTarget the service is "great for a certain portion of the market" but "just not going to be there" for the largest enterprises.
- **Why it matters:** the risk to workforce management vendors is buyers who stop shopping. Opus Research's Ian Jacobs says Salesforce needs to make its service "easy enough for Salesforce customers to stop shopping."

Fin, two weeks after the sale closed

- Salesforce told analysts the average Fin setup takes 18 days, mostly without engineering help, Opus Research reports.
- Salesforce says Fin runs most conversations on its own models, which makes it cheaper to run. Fin is also sold to companies using Zendesk's helpdesk.

European telecom groups pick different AI agent vendors

- Liberty Global signed a three-year partnership with Sierra on 23 September. It will roll out Sierra's agents in phases across about 80 million fixed and mobile connections in Europe.
- Telecompaper reports the rollout has started in the UK, with Ziggo, Telenet and Virgin Media among the named operators. No contract value was published.
- Deutsche Telekom's chief AI officer told The Next Web the share of interactions never reaching a human rises one to two percentage points a month. He gave no starting figure.
- He said a new use case climbs from 20% handled by AI to 40% within a couple of months. Above 80% is "really, really hard." Deutsche Telekom works with Decagon and other startups.
- **Our view:** two large European telecom groups are now working with different vendors. Deutsche Telekom's account gives workforce planners a steady monthly shift of work away from people, with the climb getting steeper above 80%.

Vendors start planning for customers' own AI agents

- Parloa argued on 24 September that standard contact-centre staffing formulas, known as Erlang, assume random, independent callers. Customers' personal AI agents break that assumption.
- In Parloa's illustrative model, if 10% of tasks shift to personal agents, contacts rise 28% while customer tasks rise only 5%. These are modelled figures, not customer data.
- Lorikeet launched a product for this traffic on 17 September. Sierra's co-founder expects personal agents to talk directly to business agents within about six months.
- **Why it matters:** this is the first vendor case in our coverage that AI could make contact-centre forecasting harder, not easier. That lands directly on workforce management.
- **Watch:** Parloa's WAVE event in Berlin on 7 and 8 October promises an early look at new capabilities.

California's five bills are still unsigned

- AB 1883 (emotion inference and neural data), SB 947 (automated discipline and firing) and SB 951 (AI layoff notices) remain with the Governor.

- So do AB 1609 (customer-service chatbots and a 15-minute human connection) and AB 1331 (workplace surveillance).
- The Governor acted on about 100 other bills this week. None of the five was among them.
- A bill not vetoed by 30 September becomes law.

Other regulatory developments

- **Colorado:** the Attorney General had promised revised automated-decision rules by 23 September. That day the page dropped the date. The draft now comes at least five days before the 26 October hearing.
- **United States:** a Federal Communications Commission proposal from March would cap the share of telecom calls answered offshore. On 25 September two senators asked it to add a right to reach a human when AI answers.
- **United Kingdom:** the government confirmed October start dates for several employment measures on 25 September. Guaranteed hours and shift-notice rights, which would change contact-centre scheduling, are still dated only "2027."
- **Connecticut:** AI disclosure in mass-layoff notices starts on 1 October. The state's notice page still does not mention AI.
- **Kistler v. Eightfold AI:** the case tests whether AI scores of job applicants fall under US credit-reporting law. There is no ruling yet; a filing on 24 September points the judge to a recent decision.
- **European Union:** no enforcement action on workplace emotion recognition surfaced in the official sources checked.

Other company developments

- **NiCE:** made its Cognigy AI agents generally available in India on 23 September, hosted in Mumbai. They cover Hindi, Tamil, Bengali and Hinglish, and can run without NiCE's CXone platform.
- **Level AI:** launched Context Handoff. When its AI agent passes a call to a person, the person sees the customer's mood, the reason for the call and what the bot already tried.
- Level AI claims the handoff saves 60 to 90 seconds per escalated call. It gives no customer or sample.
- **Decagon:** is building a team for Belgium, the Netherlands and Luxembourg. It reports Rituals launched its AI concierge across 19 countries and 15 languages in two months.
- **Wonderful:** opened a London office, led by a former Salesforce vice president.
- **Five9:** said on 15 September that its voice AI agents reach Europe on 3 November. Its shares hit a 52-week high on 21 September, after a broker raised its price target.
- **Zoom:** a product head said Zoom now pairs post-call surveys with "implied resolution," graded by an AI model, according to a SiliconANGLE column.

- **Sela:** raised \$21 million for AI voice agents that help lenders sell mortgages.

What to watch

- **California, by 30 September:** action on AB 1883, SB 947, SB 951, AB 1609 and AB 1331. Without a veto, each becomes law.
- **Connecticut, 1 October:** whether the state publishes a layoff-notice form that covers AI.
- **Salesforce, October:** the UK and EU launch, and when workforce management ships.
- **Zendesk, within six months:** the promised pricing announcements.
- **Customer events:** Parloa on 7 and 8 October, Five9 on 12 and 13 October, Observe.AI on 13 and 14 October.
- **Colorado, by 21 October:** the revised automated-decision rules, ahead of the 26 October hearing.
- **Actimize:** whether NiCE or Brookfield confirms a deal.
- **Listen Labs:** Salesforce's reported acquisition talks remain unconfirmed, with no agreement or denial.
- **Prediction updates:** the next full check of the annual report's eighteen predictions is due next week.
- **New companies surfaced, not yet tracked:** Sela (mortgage voice agents), Aissist (scores AI and human agents against the same standards) and TeleAI (automatic scoring of outbound calls).

Sources

Detailed citations

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